

Gadgetshala: The Classroom that India's Most Forgotten Children Finally Deserve



“For millions of children across the country who are being left behind in the digital era, without access to a computer or an internet connection, there is hope.”

Imagine having an exam to study for – but no study material whatsoever. This is the reality of millions of children across India today. As the pandemic pushed schools online with sudden haste, and virtual classes and homework became the new normal on Zoom and WhatsApp, a massive population of slum-dwelling, migrant-settlement-dwelling and disadvantaged urban children have more or less vanished from the education map. Not because they don’t want to study – they do – but because they have no device to do so.

It was eerily silent at Hamari Pahchan NGO’s office in Mumbai’s Gandhi Nagar, until they started the Gadgetshala – a play on words combining gadget and pathshala or school in Hindi. But starting a digital school seems to be just the right thing to do here. Children from Gandhi Nagar don’t have access to digital tools, and that’s not for lack of trying.

The Problem: A Divide That Grows Wider Every Year

We are told that India is in the middle of an unprecedented digital revolution. 954 million internet subscribers, the world’s fastest 5G rollouts and over 1.1 billion UPI transactions in a single year would suggest that yes, India is in the midst of a massive digital revolution. But there are two Indians here. And that gulf is only growing.

29M

A series of illustrations for a poster campaign organized by the Indian Education Ministry. The aim was to highlight kids in India who have little to no access to digital technology.

11%

About 40% of rural children had access to live online classes during the lockdown phase of the COVID-19 pandemic, according to the findings from the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) 2021.

2.7%

60% Poorest 20% households have access to a computer: Oxfam India

Oxfam India's Inequality Report 2022 discovered that only 8.9% of the poorest 20% of households have internet access, contrasted with over 50% of the wealthiest 20% of households. Lockdowns that pushed online learning for schoolchildren have left the poorest – and therefore, most disconnected – kids behind. And often, learning has stopped altogether.

This is how Gadgetshala was born, NOT as a charity project but as an effort for educational justice.

What Gadgetshala Actually Does

Gadgetshala is the digital arm of the Drishti Initiative, Hamari Pahchan's flagship education programme that has been running informal weekly classes for out-of-school children and under-served communities since 2015. Where Drishti lays the foundations by teaching children basic communication skills, life skills and introductory computing, Gadgetshala builds on that by bringing the internet, smartphones, tablets and laptops into communities where reliable access to technology has never been possible.

How It Works

Through the initiative, Gadgetshala has provided hundreds of slum dwelling children access to computers and internet connection. Along with using the computer to practice typing, the children are organised in small groups under the mentorship of the Gadgetshala team. The sessions are held on a regular basis. But there is far more to these sessions than just learning how to type. The children are learning email and how to use it responsibly, they are learning how to search the internet safely, and how to tap into government programmes and scholarships online.

Hamari Pahchan started as a social enterprise when Mr. Tarun Mathur, founder and CEO, was stuck at home during the COVID-19 lockdown. An international chess player and full-time officer with Air India, Tarun has always used his strategic mind for competitive pursuits—until he turned strategic for social change. When schools went online, Mr. Mathur noticed that the Drishti kids he had grown to care for lacked the gadgets and connectivity to keep up with their new lessons. Thus, Gadgetshala was born: the only classroom format available in a world on lockdown.

Why This Matters Beyond the Classroom

It's easy to think of Gadgetshala as an education programme, but digital literacy has become so fundamental that it is not just another subject at school, but the basis for participation in all other aspects of life.

What does being digitally excluded really mean in 2026? Not being able to apply for a government scholarship that only gets announced on the website of the relevant body? Not being able to apply for an Aadhaar-linked microfinance or micro-insurance product because you can't access the internet to verify your identity through the UID number and phone number that are linked to it? Not being able to establish whether you have a legitimate claim to certain rights because you can't find the relevant government website or download the relevant government mobile app? And now, being locked out of every job that requires you to type and use a computer after the first semester of engineering school because you have never had access to a computer to practice on one? India is a rapidly digitalising economy. Every year that a child grows up without basic computer proficiency is a year during which that child's deficits get worse and worse.

Oxfam report shows that digital inequalities reproduce themselves and worsen real-world inequalities. Gadgetshala is our intervention to bust that cyclical pattern.

More Than 15,000 Children – and Counting

Since the inception of the Drishti Project in 2015, more than 15,000 children have benefited through the umbrella program. Gadgetshala specifically has been empowered with devices for more than 100 children to practice and learn through focused sessions. Further, the organisation has trained and empowered 5000+ women through various digital skills training programs across different cities. What many perceive as solely a children's issue, the NGO is working to address the challenges for women and the community at large.

At the end of every Gadgetshala session, kids walk out with capability - the ability to look something up. The confidence to search and find what they need. The knowledge that the digital world isn't somewhere 'out there' but right there on the screen in front of them.

What You Can Do

Despite being mostly DIY Gadgetshala is easy to support – all it takes is a ₹299 donation to Gadgetshala for stationery & other supplies or a ₹799 donation for data for a session! If you are a student or working young professional you can make a huge difference in a child's life by dedicating an hour a week to mentor and teach them 1 digital skill every week.

India is rapidly transforming into a digital world and at Gadgetshala we can't let children be left behind in this movement.

A shala (school) is not just defined by the four walls of a physical building. For many, a shala opens its doors to nurture the young minds that require the greatest attention and support. Gadgetshala is exactly such a school.

To Support

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Donations are eligible for tax exemption under Section 80G of the Income Tax Act.